‘the truth will be out soon’. Bhagat later became the IB director and presided over the ouster of one of its joint directors, Ratan Sehgal, who was caught having secret meetings with US intelligence officials in Delhi in 1996.

18 December 1994. The next to meet me was CBI Additional Director D R Karthikeyan. P M Nair took me to Karthikeyan who headed the special investigation team that was probing the Rajiv Gandhi assassination case. It was only three years since the former Indian Prime Minister was killed by a human bomb of the Liberation Tigers of Tamil Eelam (LTTE).

Karthikeyan was visibly worked up, probably because of some tangles in another assignment.

His first question was blunt: ‘What is your relationship with the two Maldivian women?’

I replied I had never met the women till my arrest and the investigators brought me face to face with the co-accused.

Now he was asking questions which I had answered several other officers many times. I presumed that Karthikeyan, unlike Bhagat, had not gone through the case files, but his questions were equally sharp. Having dealt with hardcore militants of the LTTE, grilling me would have been a child’s play for the officer. Firing a question, he would expect an immediate answer; he disliked silence. I tried my best to keep up with his pace, giving answers immediately. Whenever I had to think over something like a date, I told him I need to think. He questioned me for four hours.

Later I understood that both Bhagat and Karthikeyan were reviewing the draft of the CBI investigation report to ensure that the conclusions were watertight. At the beginning of the questioning, Karthikeyan had appeared to be an irritable man, but at the end of four hours he looked content, and said, ‘truth will prevail’. It appeared to me that CBI officers were instructed to say this like gospel at the end of each interrogation.

While leaving Karthikeyan’s room, I read a poster on his wall that said ‘Pray to God, he will come. He will not come quick, but be assured He will come.’